

The AIC Cookbook

Customized recipes (+ ingredients)
to **chop up** your self-doubt and
make **the secret sauce** for **feeling**
good enough.

**ANTI
IMPOSTER
CLUB**

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Introduction

Dear AIC member,

welcome to your own personal copy of the Anti Imposter Club Cookbook! If you have made the effort to purchase this cookbook, you are already an outlier. Because by doing so you are showing me and yourself that you are serious about making a real change to your life. You are willing to actually take action and handle the sacrifices that come with rediscovering your self-esteem, the time and effort spent on preparing the recipes in this cookbook and the discomfort you are going to feel as you go out into the real world to practice rejection and being healthily selfish.

And that has become incredibly rare. Too many people these days love to read all the books and listen to all the podcasts but they never actually put any of the mindset nudges they bathe themselves in into action. But that's where change is made, in the doing, not in the reading or listening. So my respect for you is already immense and you are more than deserving of being supported, which I hope I can provide with the following pages.

Here is what you can expect.

The Anti Imposter Cookbook - Premium Package is split into 6 recipes which are designed to boost your sense of being good enough from different angles. They orient themselves along the learnings from my eBook *The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula* and aim to retrain your mind to be ok with giving rejection, to be ok with being selfish, to be ok with saying no, etc. through physical action.

Recipes number 1 to 3 in that context form the foundation for rediscovering your sense of being good enough and collecting the currencies of self-esteem

by helping you figure who you are (on a deeper and more inward level than you might have considered so far in your life). Hence, I would recommend you start with those. Specifically, they are designed to help you figure out what your values, wants and inner rules are that you want to live by, and thereby give yourself certainty about what and who is important to you in life and therefore what and who you dedicate yourself to to earn the currencies of self-esteem that come with that.

To support you in that endeavour of dedication and rejection of the alternatives, this Cookbook offers recipes 4 to 6, which are step-by-step guides to practice rejection by knowing how to saying 'no', to keep you moving even when the discomfort you are going to face as you practice rejection and being more selfish puts you into overthinking spirals, and to embrace the whole you and keep yourself in balance by stopping to suppress your Id and therefore part of your personality.

Each recipe follows the structure of describing its purpose, followed by the method of how to "prepare" the outcome it aims to achieve and giving you a set of ingredients readily laid out for you to follow that method.

Before I let you crack on, one last ask for a favour. Please don't let your journey of rediscovering your self-esteem be unshared. I take great joy out of every message, email or picture I get tagged in that shows people taking action to make a real change to their lives. So feel free to connect with me either on Instagram @antiimposterclub or by sending me an email (stefan@antiimposterclub.com). I can't wait to hear about your stories.

So without further ado, let's get cooking.

Recipe #1:
Unlocking the Essence of You:
Your Values

Looking back on my journey to rediscovering my self-esteem, all the journal entries I have written, all the talks that I have had with myself and all the lessons that I learned from that, there is one thing that stands out as arguably being the most important aspect of having high self-confidence. So important in fact, that I have not only dedicated this recipe to it but also recipe #2 and #3. Because they all work together in helping you figure out the answer to one crucial question: Who are you? (And who do you want to be?).

This is absolutely key.

Because as an important reminder from my eBook, it is that feeling of knowing who you are, knowing where you are going in life, and of knowing what's important to you, which is a prerequisite for feeling good enough and secure in yourself.

Only by having deep self-awareness are you able to pick a focus, a direction, and a purpose in life, which you can dedicate yourself to and thereby be rewarded with the currencies of self-esteem. Only by knowing who you are, can you pin down what your intrinsic needs are and become selfish about meeting them. Only by knowing yourself, are you able to determine which job, hobbies, friends, partner, i.e., every life choice you are ever going to make will make you feel good about yourself. And therefore also which options won't and should therefore be rejected.

And it doesn't stop there, knowing yourself will also help you deal with any discomfort that you are going to face as you embrace rejection and develop a healthy level of selfishness. Because knowing yourself, appreciating your strengths, and becoming aware that you have great qualities allows you to develop a bit of an 'F*** you'-attitude. Which makes embracing discomfort feel less daunting as it enables you to tell yourself "Ah f*** it, let's take the risk, even

if this goes wrong I am still a good person because of X, Y and Z.” At the same time, as you get to know and accept your weaknesses you will become more resilient to the fear of criticism or being rejected. Because if you know your errors, you also know which things aren’t your flaws, and therefore which things you and others can’t use to hurt yourself.

In other words, just to be really clear, knowing who you are is power.

But, what determines who you are?

Let’s start with your inner compass that underpins everything: your values.

If you have been in the self-improvement space for a little while you will have come across one piece of advice over and over again: Figure out what your values are.

And if you are anything like me you will have ignored that advice for as long as possible because you didn’t really know what it means.

Time to stop the ignorance.

Because your values are pretty much the single most powerful decider for how you are going to feel about every decision that you are ever going to make in life.

That’s the nature of values. And I wish I had realised that sooner.

What is a value?

To put it into the words of clinical psychologist Julie Smith: “If you imagine your life as a journey, a value is like a path that extends throughout the whole of your life and it is something that you subconsciously always choose to stay close to when you can.”

Your values are in essence the attitudes and characteristics that you hold close to yourself because they are important to you. They are the principles and beliefs that guide your decisions, actions, and behaviours. They are basically a way of telling yourself how you want to be across all aspects of your life, your career, your relationships, or your hobbies.

To give you an example from my own life, one of my values is enthusiasm. To me it is important that I feel energised in my work, my relationships, and my hobbies. Because I like myself the most when I am bubbly, when I get passionate talking about my interest, and when I am around people who bring energy that I can bounce off. And so I always try to choose my work, hobbies and friends partly based on whether they bring out enthusiasm in me.

Unfortunately, life sometimes drags you away from your 'value paths'. For instance, during my first job out of uni, I encountered a work environment where people didn't necessarily have the highest work morale, where the work wasn't necessarily challenging and therefore boring rather than exciting to me. And so not surprisingly it drained me of my enthusiasm for work.

So much so that after just 10 months of working there I decided to leave and move to a different company. And thank god, I did. Because, in my new workplace I was all of a sudden surrounded by people that shared the same enthusiasm as me for working hard, where the work itself was challenging and where the energy people brought to the office fuelled my passion for my job. And guess what, I all of a sudden felt energised. I all of a sudden looked forward to work and put in more effort, which allowed me to progress in my skills and expertise. I all of a sudden radiated positive energy that allowed me to build great relationships. In other words, I all of a sudden naturally adopted behaviours that allowed me to earn currencies of self-esteem.

However, if I hadn't been aware that enthusiasm is one of my values, I would not have realised that I was living out of line with it and therefore I would not have been able to be selfish about it and reject my old workplace to take myself to a better environment.

Hence, the overplayed advice does ring true after all: Figure out what your values are. And you will reap the benefits from it.

Here is how:

Method (à la Dr. Aziz Gazipura)

At the core of the following recipe is something that is as old as humanity itself, something that has allowed cavemen to make fire, Thomas Edison to invent the lightbulb, and James Dyson to design the most efficient piece of household kit ever: Experimentation.

Following in the footsteps of these greats, in the following you're going to use experimentation to figure out your values.

You're going to come up with a hypothesis, then you're going to test it, then you're going to see how well it works, then you're going to improve it and then you're going to repeat that cycle: Test, Evaluate, Improve. The only difference being that you are not going to try to find an even better vacuum cleaner design but that you are going to try to figure out your values.

Let's look at each step of that cycle in turn.

Step 1: Create Your Values Hypothesis

The first thing I want you to do is to just pick 5 values that you think are your values. We will call this list your ‘Values Hypothesis’.

Importantly, don’t overthink this stage too much. The intention behind this first step is just to give us something to work with in the later stages of this recipe. So, just pick the ones that come to your mind first and jot them down immediately.

Plus, it is usually those that come up first when prompted that are our true intrinsic unfiltered thoughts. Only once we start overthinking them we end up in a cycle of “what would be good values to have”. The problem with that is that this overthinking is basically synonymous with thinking “What does society think are good values to have?”. And that’s not what we’re here for. Where not here to feed a society-pleaser persona, we’re here to get to know our true self. So don’t overthink it.

If you’re nonetheless struggling to pick 5 values from scratch, have a look at the ‘Value bank’ worksheet in the ‘ingredients’ section of this recipe to get some inspiration for which values to claim as your own. Write them down and hang them up somewhere in your house/flat/dorm/caravan where you can see them everyday to remind yourself of what you chose.

Step 2: Collect Data

After you have successfully chosen 5 values and claimed them to be your values, this is where things get interesting.

Because for the next 7 days I want you to consciously watch yourself. Using the journaling template attached to this recipe I want you to do daily reflections on

what is happening in your life and more importantly, how you respond to these 'happenings'. In other words, I want you to reflect on what thoughts cross your mind as you go through your week, what emotions you feel in response to certain life situations, and how you behave as a result of that.

To illustrate this consider, for instance: How do you respond to annoying messages? How do you interact with your peers? Which news gets you excited? What is a memory from your day or week that seems to linger longer than others? And so on.

The reason I want you to do these reflections is because of simple psychology. What most people don't realise is that you are not actually controlling your thoughts most of the time. In an attempt to save energy your brain is flying on autopilot most of the day by handing control over to your subconscious mind. And as a result of that you are actually never really consciously aware of what your thoughts are, why you make decisions the way you make them, why you form judgements in the way you do, etc. They just all happen automatically.

However, it is those automated responses that are a strong indicator for what is important to you, that show your inner principles and guidelines that you hold close to yourself. In other words, it is those automatically generated thoughts, emotions, and behavioural responses that are a strong indicator for what your values really are.

And so by sitting down and consciously journaling, you give yourself a chance to become aware of these automations and are able to uncover where they are coming from.

Step 3: Evaluate Your Data

As a logical next step after you complete your 7 days of reflections I want you to now hone in on all the experiences you had during the week and look at them through the value lens.

Using the attached 'Evaluation template' analyse those moments where you felt positive emotions like happiness or contentment and reflect on why you felt these emotions. Did you feel happy when you offered that lady a seat on the tube because you advocate kindness? And is that because kindness is something that is really important to you?

Then do the same thing with the opposite end of the spectrum. Analyse the moments where you felt negative emotions like anger or frustration and reflect on why you felt those emotions. Did you feel annoyed at work because just like me you didn't feel enthusiastic about it? And is being enthusiastic something that you hold close?

As you do this, the key question you are trying to answer in the back of your head is "What is the underlying theme behind each of these experiences?" What values did I play with in each of these moments?"

The intention of this step is to gain a much clearer understanding of what kind of situations, activities and behaviours bring you positive emotions and which ones bring you negative emotions. Or in other words, this step is designed to help you gain a much better understanding of which situations, activities and behaviours are in line with what's important to you and which ones drag you away from what's important to you. Because ultimately, these things are probably your values.

Step 4: Test Your Hypothesis

Following step 3, compile a list of these things that you identified as being important to you and compare them to your initial list of 5 values, i.e., your 'Values Hypothesis'? Do they match? Were you right about yourself? Or did you notice that actually there are other things that are much more important to you that you weren't aware of?

Be honest with yourself and don't get frustrated if you weren't. As I mentioned above, we're flying on autopilot most of the day and thus aren't even aware of our thinking patterns most of the time! But, that's what's the beauty of this exercise. It allows you to really get to know yourself, to be more in touch with who you are.

After you have compared your conclusions from your reflections and your initial Values Hypothesis, adjust it accordingly. Kick off all the values that you initially picked that hardly played a role during your week and replace them with the themes/principles/guidelines that you discovered are really important to you. (Also, at this point don't feel like you have to limit yourself to keeping your Values Hypothesis as a list of 5, feel free to make it longer or shorter depending on what you concluded in your reflections.)

And then, re-test it.

Step 5: Re-Test Your Hypothesis

After you have adjusted your values list, repeat steps 2-4 of this recipe.

Watch yourself for another 7 days and reflect on your happenings and responses in the same way. Analyse your experiences once more through the value lens and become clear on what situations brought out positive and negative emotions in

you. And then ask: “What does how I acted or responded to any of these experiences tell me about myself?”

Things get interesting when you notice that the same themes, which you already identified as being important to you in the previous week, pop up again. If this happens you can be almost certain that these principles are your values.

Re-test as often as you like until you feel that you have become much more self-aware about what is important to you and therefore who you are as a person.

Spoiler alert: As a side effect of this, watch how your self-esteem grows as you start to get to know yourself and become more certain about who you are.

Goal Setting

Armed with these steps, I now want you to set yourself a goal for figuring out your values.

For that purpose, I want you to follow the SMART method, which suggests that effective and achievable goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

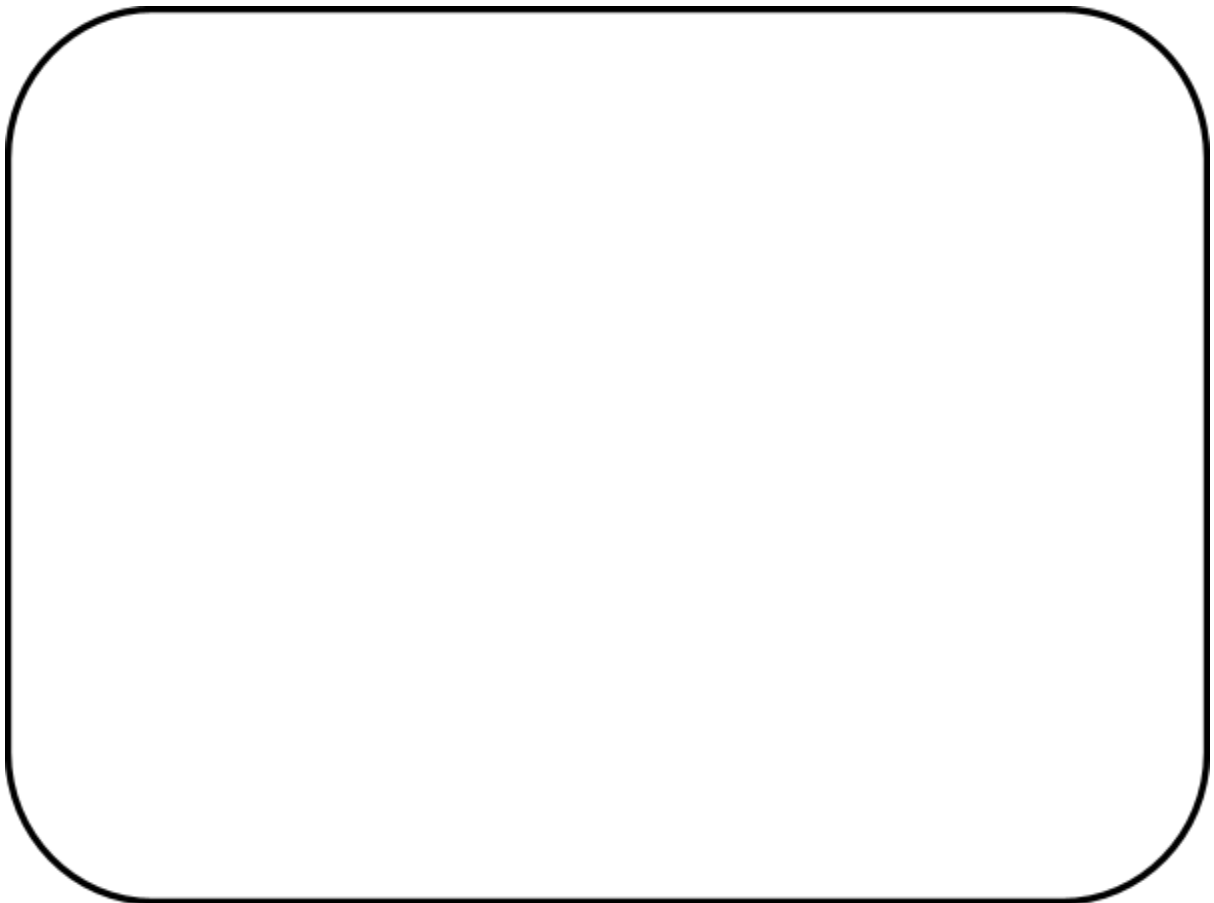
This method helps ensure that your goals are clear and well-defined so you know what exactly you want to do (specific), quantifiable to track progress (measurable), realistic and attainable based on your current resources, skills, and circumstances (achievable), aligned with your overall objectives and values (relevant), and have a specific timeframe or deadline for completion.

Here's an example of applying the SMART method to a goal:

Non-SMART Goal: "I want to figure out my values."

SMART Goal: "I will figure out my values by following the steps described in Recipe #1 of The Anti Imposter Cookbook for the next 7 days."

Importantly, when defining your goal, write it down instead of just thinking it in your head. According to Brian Tracy (author of Eat that frog!) doing so will increase your chances of achieving your goal by 5x to 10x. Hence, fill in the space below by copying down the SMART goal above or (even better) writing down your own variation of that goal:

A large, empty rounded rectangular box with a black border, intended for the user to write their SMART goal.

Ingredients

for Recipe #1

My Value Hypothesis

Value 1:

Value 2:

Value 3:

Value 4:

Value 5:

Date: _____

Values Bank

Kindness	Adventurousness	Growth	Gratitude	Empathy
Balance	Courage	Resilience	Quality-Relationships	Time-management
Optimism	Curiosity	Mindfulness	Patience	Authenticity
Intention	Appreciation	Diligence	Joy	Honesty
Integrity	Harmony	Celebration	Open-mindedness	Forgiveness
Purpose	Passion	Enthusiasm	Learning	Positivity
Responsibility	Generosity	Community	Advocacy	Accountability
Excellence	Innovation	Benevolence	Assertiveness	Simplicity
Humor	Real Connection	Solitude	Service	Fitness
Growth-mindset	Quality	Environmentalism	Hard work	Bravery
Mindful-speech	Commitment	Holistic Education	Philanthropy	Boldness
Altruism	Letting-go	Self-compassion	Empowerment	Minimalism
Inclusivity	Creativity	Courteousness	Adaptability	Experiences
Work-life-balance	Purpose	Resilience	Rest	Wisdom
Beauty	Mindful Consumption	Open-expression	Graciousness	Constructiveness
Connection	Patriotism	Pragmatism	Diversity	Courageous Vulnerability
Humility	Self-discipline	Spirituality	Physical-health	Resourcefulness

[illegible]

[illegible]

Value Testing Evaluation Template

Which moments excited me/made my day/lifted my mood/filled me with joy?

Which moments drained/annoyed/frustrated me/put me in a bad mood?

Why did these moments evoke positive/negative emotions? What was important to you in those moments?

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Are those things that are important to you in many situations? Can you identify any themes in your responses above? What values were you playing with in those moments?

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Recipe #2:
Unlocking the Essence of You:
Your wants

Looking back on my journey to rediscovering my self-esteem, all the journal entries I have written, all the talks that I have had with myself and all the lessons that I learned from that, there is one thing that stands out as arguably being the most important aspect of having high self-confidence. So important in fact, that I have not only dedicated this recipe to it but also recipe #1 and #3. Because they all work together in helping you figure out the answer to one crucial question: Who are you? (And who do you want to be?).

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And it doesn't stop there, knowing yourself will also help you deal with any discomfort that you are going to face as you embrace rejection and develop a healthy level of selfishness. Because knowing yourself, appreciating your strengths, and becoming aware that you have great qualities allows you to develop a bit of an 'F*** you'-attitude. Which makes embracing discomfort feel less daunting. It enables you to tell yourself "Ah f*** it, let's take the risk, even if

this goes wrong I am still a good person because of X, Y and Z.” At the same time, as you get to know and accept your weaknesses you will become more resilient to the fear of criticism or being rejected. Because if you know your errors, you also know which things aren’t your flaws, and therefore which things you and others can’t use to hurt yourself.

In other words, just to be really clear, knowing who you are is power.

But, what determines who you are?

With this recipe I want to revisit something that I alluded to in *The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula*: The importance of knowing what you want.

Because what you want in life does much more than just determine whether you are going to have Chinese or Italian for dinner.

Knowing what you want is pretty much the starting point for everything in life. It determines what goals we form and dedicate ourselves to, what network of people we are going to build around us and what behaviour we are going to adopt (and also reject). And with that, who we become as a person.

Because really it is that collection of goals that we dedicate ourselves to, the behaviours that we adopt to allow ourselves to achieve those goals, and the communities that we join to help with that, which shape our identities.

If your goal is to become filthy rich, drive around in Lamborghinis, check the time on your Rolex watch, while wearing a \$500 Balenciaga T-Shirt, you’re going to become exactly that, a money-driven, self-oriented, workaholic business person that showers themselves in status symbols. On the other hand, if you have this burning desire to fill your life with thrilling experiences, you’re going to become exactly that, an adventurer, a sports-fanatic, a traveller. And either is

fine. Because there is no judgement behind wanting something, it can never be right or wrong. But it does determine who you are.

To put in the words of Kyle Eschenroeder: You are what you want.

Unfortunately, most people today are completely unaware of what it is they intrinsically want and with that, who they are.

Today's society seems to be dominated by people who have become slaves to an invisible collective voice that commands them what goals they should strive for.

They let their wants be guided by the advertisements they are bombarded with. They let their behaviour, opinions, and expectations be guided by TikTok trends, Twitter debates, and podcast snippet compilations. And they have made their default to blindly chase one dopamine hit after the other, be it in the form of Instagram reels or their next Uber Eats order.

And that is very problematic.

Because what is a life in which you leave your actual intrinsic needs and wants untapped? In which you chase things that don't really motivate you, but which you only chase because everyone else is too?

If you live a life in which others make the decisions for you, in which you only ever "go with the flow", i.e., in which the others determine your wants, goals, and your behaviour, who do you become?

If these questions make you feel a bit worried, read on.

Method

The following recipe is based on one core notion: Really, most of our most intrinsic desires are already there. We just need to uncover them from underneath the mountain of goals that society tries to convince us we should chase.

For that purpose, I am going to give you two exercises, which go hand in hand and should therefore be used together in figuring out what it is that you truly intrinsically want.

Exercise 1 is called the Ying and Yang Self-audit. It is designed to use the power of reflection to figure out what your past tells you about what your wants are. However, unlike Google's Top 10 Search results that all prompt you to ask yourself the same boring questions like "What do you like doing?" I am going to give you a bit of a different approach that will hopefully make this exercise not only more fun but also more meaningful and effective.

Exercise 2 is then a prompt to go out and place 'Little Bets'. Ideally you're going to use the insights from the self-audit to guide you in terms of what things you are going to place your bets on. And no, I am not talking about the black 17 in the game of Roulette.

Enough of this mystery talk. Let's get started.

Exercise 1 - The Yin and Yang Self-Audit

Let's start this off a little unorthodox. I would bet my whole AMEX Cashback that everyone reading this has used the phrase "Life is full of ups and downs" before, right?

We often just casually say this, however, if you really think about it, this overplayed piece of life advice couldn't be more true.

No matter how good your life is, there will always be cloudy days. Even the most fulfilling job will make you feel frustrated sometimes. And even the most amazing relationship you have won't go without arguments.

Or to put it into Mark Manson's words: everything sucks, some of the time.

However, interestingly, sometimes we don't mind the shit that life throws at us. We don't change jobs after one frustrating day, or even one frustrating week if one the whole we find our work deeply fulfilling. We don't break up with our partner even after they have just cancelled our valentine's dinner if we have the most loving relationship with them.

Of course it hurts and gives us feelings of disappointment, anger and sadness, but we are willing to accept that. We are prepared to willingly face these kinds of hardship. Because we know that these hardships are just small dips in a grand scheme of things. Because we know that despite these dips our job or our partner is still exactly what we want.

Realising this is incredibly powerful. Because as you recognise that hardship is unavoidable, the question becomes not, how do I avoid the shit that life is constantly throwing at me but rather what hardship am I willing to go through?

In other words, we can choose what shit we want to go through. And if that's the case, why don't we choose the shit we don't mind too much?

Question 1 (à la Mark Manson): What shit are you willing to go through?

Hence, to start this self-audit, I want you to grab the self-audit template that comes with this recipe (or your own reflection tool of choice) and start writing down all of the times in which you faced hardship. In which you, for instance, sacrificed sleep, in which you ended up in recurring overthinking spirals, in which you experienced heartache. And so on and so forth. It could be that time you had to pull all nighters at uni to get your coursework done. It could be that time you went to a speaking event for the first time where you were shitting yourself because you were worried about losing your voice, forgetting what you were going to say and embarrassing yourself as a result of that. Or it could be a big argument you had with your partner when they didn't support you as much as you wanted them to when you were stressed because of family drama.

And now look at that list and consider: Which of these moments of hardship did you not really mind? In which cases were you willing to accept these 'downs' and power through the temporary pain? Which of these moments do you look back at and think to yourself "Damn that really drove me to the edge... worth it though..."?

The answers to these questions is a great starting point for figuring out what your wants are in life, what the things are that give you such a sense of enjoyment and purpose that you don't even mind going through some shit along the way.

Question 2: What Activities Lead You to "Flow"? What did you use to do for the sheer fun of it that you aren't doing anymore?

Following on from the first question, I now want you to reflect on the complete opposite of hardship. I want you to detangle what activities put you in a so-called flow state.

What is flow you may ask.

To put it simply, flow is a positive state we experience when we are totally connected to our performance. Flow is when you're so focused on something that you completely zone out, that you lose track of time, that you seemingly turn off the rest of the world and the chaos of thoughts in your head and that you just fully indulge in what we are doing, almost as if you go into a trance-like state. It's, for example, that sensation Formula 1 drivers describe as "becoming one with the car". It's when a surgeon operates for 18 hours without stopping. It's when jazz musicians lose themselves in the performance as they are improvising over a beat. And according to science it is one of the most joyous experiences we can have.

Because from a neurological perspective, research shows that long periods of focus make us spend more time in the prefrontal cortex. And therefore we are less likely to dwell on the mostly negative thoughts in our amygdala (emotional centre of our brain), which makes us happier.

Research by Cal Newport, author of Deep Work, takes this even further and says that we are actually happier when we are focused on some really hard work that creates meaningful, satisfying output rather than when we are relaxing. (Which explains why we sometimes long for the working week after a weekend since we enjoy the challenge and progress, and get energised by work that's important to us.)

Hence, for the second part of this self-audit, once again grab the self-audit template and write down all the activities that get you into the flow state.

And if you're up for a mental challenge...dig even deeper.

Technically, once we have identified what activities put us into flow, we could leave it at that. However, if you want to get a bit of a deeper understanding of yourself and what drives you, you can also ask yourself, what are the cognitive principles behind these activities that make them so enjoyable for you?

For example, if editing photos in Photoshop puts you into flow? What is it that you enjoy about it so much? Is it because you love the aspect of creativity/creating something? Is it because you have got a thing for aesthetics?

Having an understanding of these inner drivers is an incredible insight into yourself as it enables you to look for activities that encompass them and that are therefore likely to energise you, give you enjoyment and ultimately give you something that you identify with. And that's exactly what we are going to do next.

Exercise 2 - Place Little Bets

If you do exercise 1 diligently you will now have a much better understanding of what drives you. However, the problem is that this understanding is just a thesis. It's the result of mental roleplay with ourselves. But what we lack is hard evidence that what we have come up with, is actually really what we want. This is why I have included the following exercise into this recipe.

In essence, this exercise boils down to helping you develop a bias towards action.

Because a bias for action is the best way to gather data for testing our thesis and to ensure that we stay connected to reality. Instead of spending too much time imagining what things we might want and what they might be like, we're often better off simply trying them out. Because our imaginations are in all cases not

the reality. If we feel like we want something, we are very likely to romanticise that thing.

For instance, we might be convinced that we need to become an actor after seeing a movie. It's not until we start the process of taking acting lessons and going to auditions that we can actually know whether we like acting. The repetition of scenes, constant rejection, and emotional labour can only be understood with direct experience.

The glittering path may look better at first, but as we begin to walk it we begin to see the hidden costs: the shallow friendships, the enemies made, the underappreciated role of luck, and all of the other little details hidden from view.

However, the more often we do take action, we will slowly but surely figure out the things we want and the things that we don't want. Eventually our desires will flow from our experience instead of outside influences and imaginations.

In combination with that, I also want you to pay attention to something else, namely "mimetic desire", i.e., the things you want when you are around different people.

Because a large part of any person's attraction is that other people are attracted to them. If all your friends are into the gym, you are likely to be a regular gym goer as well. Equally, if all your friends are massively into sitting around drinking and gossiping about others, you're probably going to be a similar kind of gossip.

Realising this can be really powerful to figure out what you want. Because if you place yourself in a community of people whose wants align with yours, you're going to feel amazing. And equally, if you place yourself in a community of people whose wants don't align with yours, you're going to feel drained.

The community you pick will shape you to a degree nearly impossible to appreciate, so it's important to pick well.

Surrounding yourself with those who share similar aspirations – your crowd – will take you farther than you could ever go by yourself. Belonging to a community of like-minded individuals creates a slipstream that reassures you in your wants, makes you feel understood and good about yourself. It also makes sticking with your aims much easier, gives you a support and accountability group, and may even turn what you want to want into your default desire.

Hence, try joining different communities and pay attention to the differences in what you want and how you feel when you're with different people. What's the vibe? Do the others' overt and covert wants immediately resonate with you? Do they align with the cognitive principles that you identified in your self-audit? Or do you feel a bit out of place? Do you feel that little stitch in your chest suggesting that you don't agree with the others?

Listen closely. Compile your own list of 'Little Bets' that you want to place using the attached template and consider why you want to place those bets. What conclusions from the Yin and Yang Self-Audit lead you to want to try those things on your list? Is it because you want to pick up a hobby again you gave up when you were younger, which used to put you into flow? Is it because you have identified creativity as a cognitive principle that brings you deep intrinsic joy making you wanna try an art class?

Furthermore, use the "Little Bets" journal template that comes with this recipe to reflect on your experiments on a regular basis. That way you're going to collect the evidence on what you thought you wanted is actually what you wanted or not.

And now, over to you.

Goal Setting

Armed with these steps, I now want you to set yourself a goal for how you are going to figure out what you intrinsically want.

For that purpose, I want you to follow the SMART method, which suggests that effective and achievable goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

This method helps ensure that your goals are clear and well-defined so you know what exactly you want to do (specific), quantifiable to track progress (measurable), realistic and attainable based on your current resources, skills, and circumstances (achievable), aligned with your overall objectives and values (relevant), and have a specific timeframe or deadline for completion.

Here's an example of applying the SMART method to a goal:

Non-SMART Goal: "I want to figure out what I want in life."

SMART Goal: "I will use the self-audit tool from Recipe #2 of The Anti Imposter Cookbook every Sunday morning after breakfast to collect insights into what brings me deep enjoyment and subsequently use that to try one new thing every month."

Importantly, when defining your goal, write it down instead of just thinking it in your head. According to Brian Tracy (author of Eat that frog!) doing so will increase your chances of achieving your goal by 5x to 10x. Hence, fill in the space below by copying down the SMART goal above or (even better) writing down your own variation of that goal:



Ingredients

for Recipe #2

The Yin & Yang Self-Audit

Yin - What shit are you willing to go through?

[illegible]

My “Little Bets”

“Little bets” that I want to place (Activities I want to try/Groups I want to join/Events I want to go to, etc.):

- _____
- Why? _____
- _____
- Why? _____
- _____
- Why? _____
- _____
- Why? _____
- _____
- Why? _____
- _____
- Why? _____
- _____
- Why? _____

“Little Bets” Journal Template

What “little bet” did I place?

What was the experience like? Did it meet my expectations? Did it change my view?

What did I like about it?

What did I dislike about it?

How were the people? What was the vibe? Did I resonate with them straight away?

How did this “little bet” change/reaffirm my wants?

Recipe #3:
Unlocking the Essence of You:
Your Bill of Rights

Looking back on my journey to rediscovering my self-esteem, all the journal entries I have written, all the talks that I have had with myself and all the lessons that I learned from that, there is one thing that stands out as arguably being the most important aspect of having high self-confidence. So important in fact, that I have not only dedicated this recipe to it but also recipe #1 and #2. Because they all work together in helping you figure out the answer to one crucial question: Who are you? (And who do you want to be?).

This is absolutely key.

Because as an important reminder from my eBook, it is that feeling of knowing who you are, knowing where you are going in life, and of knowing what's important to you, which is a prerequisite for feeling good enough and secure in yourself.

Only by having deep self-awareness are you able to pick a focus, a direction, and a purpose in life, which you can dedicate yourself to and thereby be rewarded with the currencies of self-esteem. Only by knowing who you are, can you pin down your intrinsic needs and become selfish about meeting them. Only by knowing yourself, are you able to determine which job, hobbies, friends, partner, i.e., every life choice you are ever going to make will make you feel good about yourself. And therefore also which options won't and should therefore be rejected.

And it doesn't stop there, knowing yourself will also help you deal with any discomfort that you are going to face as you embrace rejection and develop a healthy level of selfishness. Because knowing yourself, appreciating your strengths, and becoming aware that you have great qualities allows you to develop a bit of an 'F*** you'-attitude. Which makes embracing discomfort feel less daunting. It enables you to tell yourself "Ah f*** it, let's take the risk, even if

this goes wrong I am still a good person because of X, Y and Z.” At the same time, as you get to know and accept your weaknesses you will become more resilient to the fear of criticism or being rejected. Because if you know your errors, you also know which things aren’t your flaws, and therefore which things you and others can’t use to hurt yourself.

In other words, just to be really clear, knowing who you are is power.

But, what determines who you are?

After having identified the importance of figuring out your values and wants in recipes #1 and #2, there is one more element to who you are as a person that I want to zone in on. One that is so important in fact that failing to consider it would arguably render all the work you have put in within recipes #1 and #2 worthless.

This third element is almost like a hidden force that drives our behaviour on a daily basis, as if we are guided by an invisible hand, that makes us do the things that we do almost automatically, and that determines how and why we make decisions the way we do in pretty much every life situation. And therefore, which determines who we become as a result of our actions and decisions.

Psychologists call this hidden force heuristics. And they are insanely powerful.

I like to think of heuristics as subconscious, predefined, inner rules that determine how we interact with others, how we think and feel in different situations and how we respond to pretty much everything that life throws at us, be it challenges, success, stress, or even the weather. These mental rules make us think, feel, and act automatically, like robots, as if played by an invisible puppeteer and as obedient as a German Shepherd who can sense a treat coming if he’s a good boy.

The reason we have heuristics is because they save us brain power. They allow us to make decisions quickly, without our brain having to carefully consider all the pros and cons between different options every time, especially when it comes to choices we face on a regular basis, like whether or not to take an umbrella when it is raining.

However, while that's a pretty smart way of our brain to handle the huge loads of information that we are bombarded with every waking moment and while a rule like automatically taking an umbrella when it's raining is pretty useful, heuristics can also be the opposite, pretty unhelpful.

Because if you are a people-pleaser and approval-seeker par excellence, for example, you are very likely to have an inner rule that says to automatically say "yes" to everyone who asks you for a favour, even if that means cancelling plans that you have made with yourself, like finally starting that book you been wanting to read. Or you might have an inner rule that says to never share your opinion if you sense the risk of going against someone else's point of view to avoid the chance of upsetting them, even if it means never feeling part of the conversation or the group. And that's not only unhelpful but even unhealthy.

Because people-pleaser rules like those put the control over your life in the hands of others. Rules like that put the others in charge of what you spend your time on. They prevent you from focussing on your wants and from doing the things that bring you genuine enjoyment. They make you build up resentment and put you into negative thinking cycles that drain you rather than energise you.

In other words, unhealthy rules essentially draw you away from living in line with your values and from going after your wants. And therefore from collecting the currencies of self-esteem that come with that.

But luckily...no matter how powerful these rules are, no matter how good these rules are at making you act in a certain way as if guided by an invisible hand, rules are only rules. And therefore they can be broken.

In other words, you can reprogram your heuristics, you can make your own rules.

Here is how:

Method (à la Dr. Aziz Gazipura)

The following exercise is based on one simple but incredibly important realisation: Your inner rules are the result of what the conscious mind repeatedly tells the subconscious mind. Or in simpler words, they are just learned behaviour.

The reason you are a people-pleaser might be, for example, that, growing up, the only time you ever received praise was when you did everything your parents told you to do, when you didn't complain but just got on with it. Hence, over time you learned that saying "yes" when you are being asked for a favour is what you need to do to be rewarded, to feel 'good', and to feel like you're worth something. The problem is, as you reached adulthood, this learned behaviour has ingrained itself as an inner rule deep into your psyche. So much in fact that now you're not only saying "yes" to your parents' ask for a favour, but to everyone's ask for a favour. Not very healthy.

However, if behaviour like that is learned, it means we can also unlearn it and teach ourselves healthier inner rules.

This is exactly what this exercise is intended to do for you. In the following, I want you to reset your inner rules. I want you to reflect on what rules you currently live by, keep, adapt or replace them with healthier rules and subsequently design what we will call your personal “Bill of Rights”.

I like to call it that because if you really think about it, rules are exactly that, permissions and rights to do something. They define what you are allowed to do. And so, with this exercise, I want you to define for yourself what you are allowed to do. I want you to give yourself written permission to live by your values and go after your wants.

On top of that - and this is absolutely key - I will give you a reminder tool that will allow you to frequently remind yourself of your Bill of Rights, with the aim that the repeated recall of your rules will reprogram them into your mind.

So without further ado, let's get into it.

Designing your “Bill of Rights”

As with the other two recipes designed to help you figure out who you are and who you want to be, at the core of figuring out your inner rules lies developing self-awareness and being honest with yourself.

For that purpose, I want you to start by taking the attached journal template and reflect on your everyday life. Because ultimately, this is where our inner rules are in action.

Start by mentally going through everything that happened during the last week and write down how you felt in different situations. In that context, pay particular attention to moments where you felt some inner conflict. Where you, for instance, agreed to take on extra work when really, you wanted to say “no”.

Or where you held back from speaking up because you were worried about what the others would think of you, even though you know that's a stupid way to think.

These are exactly the moments where by reflecting upon them you can learn a lot about yourself, the inner rules you currently have, but also the inner rules you would like to have.

With that in mind, I want you to analyse those moments in detail to figure out what rule you were playing with in these moments. Why didn't you speak up? What inner rule held you back? Was it "Never speak up if you could end in an argument"?

Alternatively, you could just conclude something like "I am just not someone that speaks up, I get really anxious when I do. I get afraid that the others give me weird looks or disapprove of me and my opinion, or that I end up in some sort of conflict."

Maybe you even conclude at the same time "I thought about doing it for a long time at that moment but I just couldn't bring yourself to do it (as if some hidden force was holding me back), even though I know that everyone is entitled to share their opinion...I wish you would have just done it!"

Now, this is where things get interesting.

Because next, I want you to mentally recreate that situation in your head but this time, imagine that you are free of guilt, anxiety, fear and doubt. Imagine that regardless of what you say or do, you won't feel any fear of what others will think, for instance. You won't get anxious about getting weird looks. What would you do in that same situation?

The answer to that question is what we are interested in. Because the answer to that question is the inner rule/permission/right you would like to live by. We just need to formulate it.

For that purpose, I want you to take the “My Bill of Rights” template attached to this recipe and write a sentence beginning with “I have the right to ...”, followed by the permission you want to give yourself.

To carry on with the above example, the answer to the question of what you would do if you didn't have any fear of speaking up, is probably going to be that you are just going to do it! Because while the others might not like your opinion, might disapprove of you, or might not even be interested in hearing it, you have the right to share it, so why don't you just give yourself permission to do so?

Hence, as you write this conclusion down and deeply resonate with the idea that you would like to be someone that isn't shy to say what they think, regardless of what looks the others are going to give you, regardless of what the others are going to say, then give yourself the written permission to do so by writing into your Bill of rights template:

I have the right to speak up and share my opinion whenever I feel the urge to do so. The others might not like my opinion, might disapprove of me, or might not even be interested in hearing it, but I have the right to share it.

This sounds overly simple, but is incredibly effective. By consciously deciding to make it a rule and writing it down, it becomes a lot easier to actually do so. In line with research the act of writing down takes your goal of being a certain way out of your mind and makes it visible and real. And it enhances our commitment to actually applying our new inner rule to our daily life.

Based on the work of the famous psychologist Robert Cialdinin (Author of the worldwide bestseller *Influence*) the act of writing something down in a way re-confirms our belief into something. In this case, in who we want to be. Further, the act of writing involves effort and therefore we value the outcome that is achieved at the end of that effort, because we don't want that effort to be for nothing. However, that is only the case if we actually stick to the rule that we just set for ourselves, because then the effort of writing it down wasn't for nothing. Hence, writing down the rules we want to live by, makes us value them more and increases our commitment to them. Which is why you should do it if you want to effectively give yourself permission to live in line with your values and go after your wants.

Now that you have formulated one of your rights, repeat this process for the rest of the situations you identified during your reflection in which you felt some inner conflict until you have your complete own Bill of Rights. To give you a few more examples of what other permissions/rules you might set for yourself, have a look at my personal Bill of Rights below:

1. I have the right to approach anyone I want to start a conversation with, regardless of whether they are standing in a group and are already involved in a group conversation.
2. I have the right to change the subject of conversation or end the conversation whenever I would like to do so.
3. I have the right to say "no" to anything I don't want to do for any reason, without any excuse or justification, just because I don't want to.
4. I have the right to ask for what I want. If that's a physical thing, someone's help, or someone else doing something for me. Asking for favours also builds trust.
5. I have the right to ask questions whenever I want to know something.

6. I have the right to offer/sell anything, especially my own ideas, to anyone.
(And they have the right to say no).
7. I have the right to question others and negotiate if they say “no” at first.
8. I have the right to disagree with others.
9. I have the right to share my perspective, even if others may disagree or feel temporarily uncomfortable.
10. I have the right to make mistakes, mess up and not be perfect.
11. I have the right to not take responsibility for others, including their problems and emotions.
12. I have the right to not anticipate others' wishes and needs. If they have them they can express them. (However, I do like being thoughtful so still listen carefully once they express their wishes).
13. I have the right to be treated with respect.
14. I have the right to expect honesty and integrity from others.
15. I have the right to feel and express all my feelings, including grief, anger, fear, and sadness.
16. I have the right to do something without having to explain myself to others.
17. I have the right to look around my environment and make eye contact, even if the others perceive it as staring.
18. I have the right to speak loudly (be it in the gym, at work, or in a public space) so others can hear me fine, regardless of what the others think of what I am saying.
19. I have the right to change my mind after I commit to something.

Setting yourself up for reprogramming

Once you have completed your Bill of Rights, it is time to actually start living by those rules and permissions. However, there is obviously no way you are going to remember all of your rules straightaway, especially when you are again in a

situation where you are mentally stressing about whether you should speak up or not, you are likely to completely forget about your bill of rights and fall back into your old rule of not taking the risk of upsetting someone by sharing your opinion.

It takes time to reprogram your heuristics and make these new rules your default way of living. And moreover it takes consistent reminding yourself of how you would like to be.

Bonus: When things get messy.

While the above exercise sounds very simple (Write your Bill of Rights. Set up a reminder tool. Done.) make no mistake, reprogramming your heuristics will come with its hurdles. You will inevitably face setbacks and unwillingly follow your old people-pleaser rules. Your Super-Ego will shower you with feelings of guilt as you are breaking your old people-pleaser rules and try to get you to fall back into your old patterns. And that's ok. That's part of the process.

For these moments, go back to the "Things got messy" journal template and reflect on the situation, where you failed to live by your new rules and where your Super-Ego got the better of you in flushing you with feelings of guilt as you were about to break the old people-pleaser rule. The key questions to ask yourself then are:

What rules were you playing with at that moment?

Was the guilt you were feeling unhealthy guilt or healthy guilt?

In the above example the rules you were playing with were, for instance, "I have the right to speak up and share my opinion" (Bill of Rights rule) vs "I should never

risk conflict by speaking up or sharing my opinion if it goes against that of the others.” (People-pleaser rule).

Once you get clarity over that, you are able to make a much better judgement on which rule is the healthier one to follow for your own wellbeing. As discussed above, people-pleaser rules like these overall put the control over your life in the hands of others. They make you build up resentment, they prevent you from meeting your desire to be part of the conversation, from being part of the group and from just generally doing and saying what you think is right and should be said. They put you into negative thinking cycles that drain you as you regret not having spoken up.

And that’s very unhealthy in my opinion. And hence, the guilt to go against someone else’s opinion, to upset someone’s feelings (that you can’t control anyway), to potentially have caused an argument (which as described in *The Never Enough Formula* are actually really important for relationship-building), is in my opinion unhealthy guilt.

Would you agree?

Goal Setting

Armed with these steps, I now want you to set yourself a goal for how you are going to reflect on your own inner rules, design your own Bill of Rights and take steps to live by it.

For that purpose, I want you to follow the SMART method, which suggests that effective and achievable goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

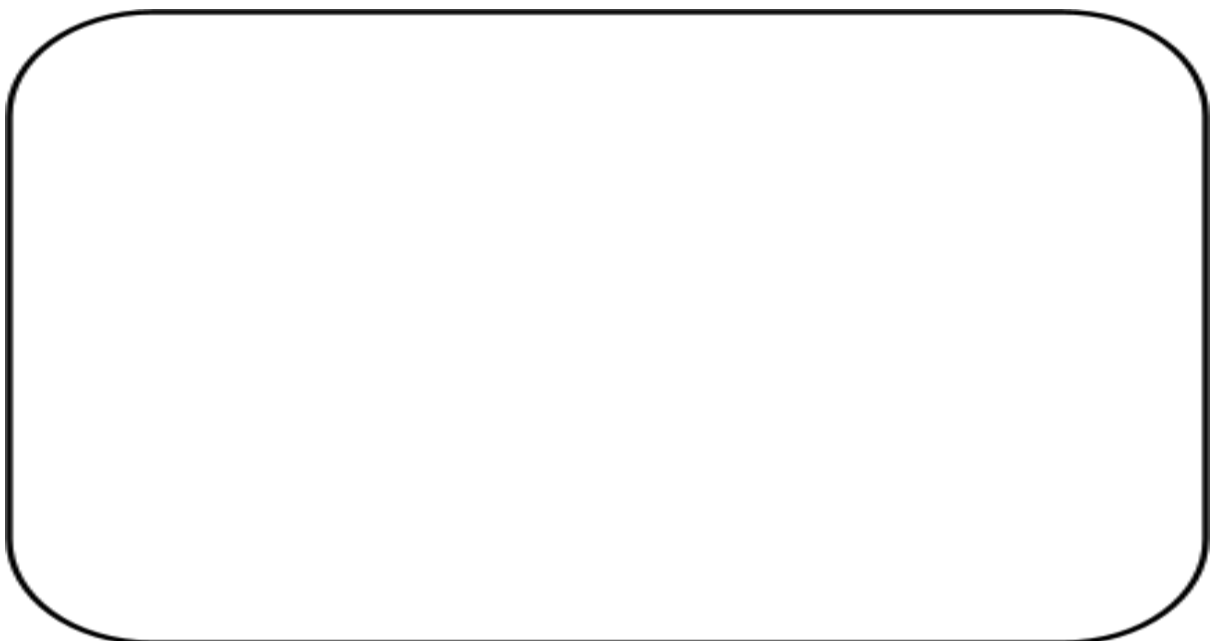
This method helps ensure that your goals are clear and well-defined so you know what exactly you want to do (specific), quantifiable to track progress (measurable), realistic and attainable based on your current resources, skills, and circumstances (achievable), aligned with your overall objectives and values (relevant), and have a specific timeframe or deadline for completion.

Here's an example of applying the SMART method to a goal:

Non-SMART Goal: "I want to set my own rules."

SMART Goal: "I will follow the steps described in Recipe #3 of The Anti Imposter Cookbook to develop self-awareness of what rules I currently follow and what rules I would like to follow and use the reflections that I am going to carry out using the journaling template to design my own Bill of Rights."

Importantly, when defining your goal, write it down instead of just thinking it in your head. According to Brian Tracy (author of Eat that frog!) doing so will increase your chances of achieving your goal by 5x to 10x. Hence, fill in the space below by copying down the SMART goal above or (even better) writing down your own variation of that goal:



Ingredients

for Recipe #3

[illegible]

This image shows a full page of white paper with horizontal dashed lines, typical of primary-ruled notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

My Bill of Rights

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____
11. _____
12. _____
13. _____
14. _____
15. _____
16. _____
17. _____

What rules were you playing with at that moment?

Was the guilt you were feeling unhealthy guilt or healthy guilt?

Recipe #4:
Saying 'No' blueprint

Let's go back to a question that many of us are probably a bit hesitant to answer:
How easy is it for you to say no?

Place yourself on the below scale...



If you are anywhere on the left, this recipe is for you.

With the following exercise I want you to make it easier for you to say 'No'. In other words, I want to make it easier for you to reject someone. Whether it's an ask for a favour, someone's opinion, or someone's behaviour.

I want to make it normal for you to say:

"No, unfortunately, I can't help you with that right now."

"No, I don't agree with you on this point."

"No, I don't want to do that."

Because being able to say 'no' is incredibly important. It puts you in control of your decision-making. Only by saying 'no' you really only end up doing the things that you actually want to do. Only by saying 'no' to the things that are not important to you, do you end up spending your time, attention, and effort on the things and people that are important to you. Saying 'no' acts as a signal to others, but more importantly ourselves, that we value our time, what we pay our attention to and who we spend time with. And, ultimately, this shows us that we value ourselves, which is a key ingredient in the recipe for rediscovering our self-esteem.

So if that's what you are after, keep reading.

Method (á la Dr. Aziz Gazipura)

Before we get into how to say 'no' I want to start off with a question that is easy to overlook but crucial to answer before we follow anything in this recipe. Especially if you are a people-pleaser who is used to saying 'yes' to every favour and ask for agreement. And that is: When should you say no?

Now, while I could give you a management consultant-eseque answer starting with "It depends..." followed by a lot of vague advice that makes you nod in agreement but doesn't mean anything, I am going to give you one simple rule which I absolutely love (and stole from the likes of Mark Manson and Dr Aziz Gazipura, thank you both). And that simple but powerful rule is:

If it's not a 'hell yes!', it's a 'no'.

Read that again. This could be life-changing.

Because what makes this rule so powerful is that by following it you ensure that you are only ever going to do the things that excite you, spend time with the people you don't have to fake laugh with, do the things that are in line with your values and that bring you closer to your goals and just generally focus on the things that are part of your intrinsic wants.

And not only will doing so maximise your happiness, but it will also earn you the currencies of self-belief. And that's what we're here for, right?

Hence, going forward, whether you are thinking about where to go next on holiday, or whether you are faced with the choice of helping an acquaintance

with their garden shed project, watch yourself, and especially your emotional response. Does the idea of building a shed get you excited? Does it make you feel pumped and wanna scream out “hell yes!”? If it doesn’t, it’s a ‘no’.

And in that case I want you do the following:

Saying ‘No’ Blueprint

Base Layer: ‘No.’ is a complete sentence.

How often have you found yourself saying “no” and immediately followed it up with “because...”? I.e., some justification that you over-exaggerated in your explanation to make it sound super important and valid, as if the situation left you no other option but to say ‘no’, hoping that you come across as “I would obviously say yes in any other case”, making it seem as if it is not your fault that you have to say ‘no’, all of which you do hoping that the other person will understand and still give you their approval.

That’s all bs.

The first thing when it comes to rejecting someone else is that everyone has the right to only do the things that they want to do and reject all the alternatives without giving any explanations for it.

This might be quite hard to understand for people-pleasers. But you don’t need to give a reason for not wanting to do something. The fact that you just don’t want to do something is reason enough. So don’t be afraid to give yourself permission to just say ‘no’ without explaining yourself.

Doing so will feel incredibly uncomfortable at first. Especially, if you saying ‘no’ to someone’s request for a favour is followed by a little moment of silence and a

sign of shock on the other person's face. And you might feel your heart beating a little faster, your breath getting a little lighter, and your forehead getting a little sweatier as your Super-Ego flushes you with feelings of guilt for letting the other person down. But that's ok, that's part of the process. That's the short-term discomfort I was talking about in *The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula*. However, the benefits you get from saying 'no' that way and powering through that short-term discomfort will be worth it.

Saying 'no' without explanation is the purest form of showing yourself that you are doing this for you. It's the purest form of showing yourself that you are in control of yourself, your time and where you direct your attention. Because there is no other factor that you hide behind and use as an excuse that justifies you saying 'no'. In these moments, you share your most intrinsic and therefore most honest feelings. You say that you don't want to do something, just because you don't want to do something.

And by the way, people will appreciate that honesty. They will repay you with respect for standing up for yourself, with trustworthiness as they realise that you are not afraid to speak the truth even if it means creating uncomfortable situations, but at least everyone knows where they are at with you.

However, of course, we are not always going to say 'no' as bluntly and (some may say rudely) as that because ultimately if we want to build great relationships that we bounce off and that lift us up it is in our best interest to be likeable.

For that purpose, it might sometimes be useful to give some sort of explanation for you saying no. However, when doing that, keep a few things in mind.

Layer 2: No apologies.

Firstly, don't apologise for saying 'no'. How often do you start an act of rejection with "I am so sorry, but..."?

If you do that sort of thing, let me ask you: Why? Because there is no reason to do so. Why should you apologise for prioritising yourself? That's what everyone should be doing anyway. Only when you prioritise yourself and make yourself happy first are you then able to support others. I like the visual below which shows this pretty well in my opinion.

[Insert image of full glass sharing with an empty glass].

Only when your glass is full are you able to share your water with someone else, whether that is in the form of love, empathy, happiness or effort.

Hence, you need to fill your own glass first. And that means prioritising yourself, doing the things that are part of your wants and that are in line with your values. Only once you make yourself happy, can you be a helping hand to others. And so, there is no reason why you should apologise for putting yourself into focus, and rejecting the alternatives by saying 'no'.

So instead of packaging your 'no' into an apology I want you to take a different approach:

Layer 3: Express warmth and appreciation

A much better alternative is to package your 'no' in an expression of warmth and appreciation. To pick up on our example of the neighbour who has asked us for help with building his garden shed. If we really don't want to help him even though we really get on well with our neighbour and hence want to say 'no' in a

nicer way than the blunt full sentence "No.", we could start our act of rejection with something like this:

Oh, thank you for seeing my skills as good enough for helping you out.

Or

Really appreciate you thinking of me to help you with such a big project.

Notice how both versions encounter the ask for favour with expressing a feeling of almost being honoured to have been asked for help. It's almost as if you put a compliment into the other person's mouth (even if they didn't intend to give you one) to which you then respond with a 'thank you'. Doing so creates a moment of connecting with the other person. Which will smoothen the rejection which you are giving in the next sentence...

Layer 4: Say no, without saying no.

Next, I want you to say 'no' without actually saying 'no'. Rather I want you to form a sentence starting with 'unfortunately'. To continue with our example above, you could say for instance:

Unfortunately, I have already made other plans for today.

Notice here, how we gave an explanation but at same time also didn't. We didn't give the details of what exactly prevents us from helping our neighbour. We have basically formulated a variation of 'I am prioritising myself today'. And that is fine, because remember: 'No' is a full sentence. You generally don't need to justify yourself or apologise for saying it. Even when formulating 'no' in a nicer way.

Really important here is, however, to avoid saying but. Notice, how we didn't say:

Really appreciate ..., but...

Because every time you use 'but' to connect two sentences, it completely negates what you say in the first sentence. Saying 'but' makes your neighbour think that you didn't mean your words of appreciation that you said in the first part of the sentence but that you only said it to be nice. I am sure we have all been in situations where someone has told us a variation of any the following.

I really like your essay, but the main character could have been a bit more expressive.

I love your outfit, but I wouldn't have matched the shoes with those jeans.

See what I mean?

Putting that little yet strong word 'but' in there completely negates the first part of the sentence and makes you almost seem dishonest. It makes you think 'How can you say that you love my outfit, when you don't think my shoes look good with those jeans? These two statements don't fit together, they are basically opposites of each other, so how can I believe that you mean what you say?'

And so equally, when you tell your neighbour

Really appreciate you thinking of me to help you with such a big project, but I have already made other plans.

What they are really hearing is:

Not really happy that you asked me for help, but just to be nice I am going to say that I am and still tell you 'no'.

Not ideal, is it. Nobody likes someone who is dishonest, fake and therefore not trustworthy. Hence, stay away from saying 'but'.

Bonus 1: Stay on your side of the net

Lastly, when you are looking to say 'no' in a nicer way, make sure you stay on your side of the net. Meaning that the justification you are giving is related to you. Notice how in the above example we focused the justification around ourselves:

Unfortunately, I have already made other plans.

We didn't go around saying something like.

Unfortunately, I really don't like the idea of helping you build a shed.

Even though the second version of saying 'no' is perfectly respectable it may come across as a suggestion that you don't like helping your neighbour in general since the focus of the justification is on the other person's interest. And as soon as this risk arises, your inner people-pleaser is going to scream loud and make it hard for you to say 'no' out of fear of upsetting the other person and losing their approval.

However, if you place the focus of your justification on yourself and your interests, in this case your plans, you avoid this risk entirely and it becomes much easier for you to say 'no'.

Bonus 2: Say 'No' early

And lastly, make sure that you say 'no' early. If after being asked for a favour you go away and say 'Let me have a think about it' and delay your response, you make it a lot harder for yourself to say 'no'.

Because by delaying your response you send the signal that you are looking for ways to make it work, which builds the inner commitment to the other person that over time is increasingly hard to get away from. It puts you into overthinking spirals that blow up the fear of disappointing the other person and crushing their hopes, making it harder for you to eventually say 'no'.

Hence, be sure to say 'no' early. Follow the first rule of this recipe for when to say 'no'. Listen to yourself and your responses, if it is not a 'hell yes!' it's a 'no'.

Now, as I said above and explained at length in *The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula*, rejecting someone will be extremely uncomfortable at first and you will without doubt fail at doing so, making you feel frustrated. However, that's fine, that's part of the process and we need those failures to learn from them and teach ourselves that saying 'no' is a right that everyone and therefore also we have and that we are allowed to make use of.

Hence, I suggest that you review recipe #3 and make saying 'no' part of your personal Bill of Rights and therefore also part of your "Things got messy" reflections that will help you learn from moments where you failed to say 'no' even when you really wanted to say it.

Goal Setting

Armed with these steps, I now want you to set yourself a process goal for how you are going to say 'no' going forward to prioritise yourself and ensure that you spend most of your time on the things that genuinely excite you, that you do with a smile on your face and which don't put you in a situation where you feel the urge to pretend to be someone else.

For that purpose, I want you to follow the SMART method, which suggests that effective and achievable goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

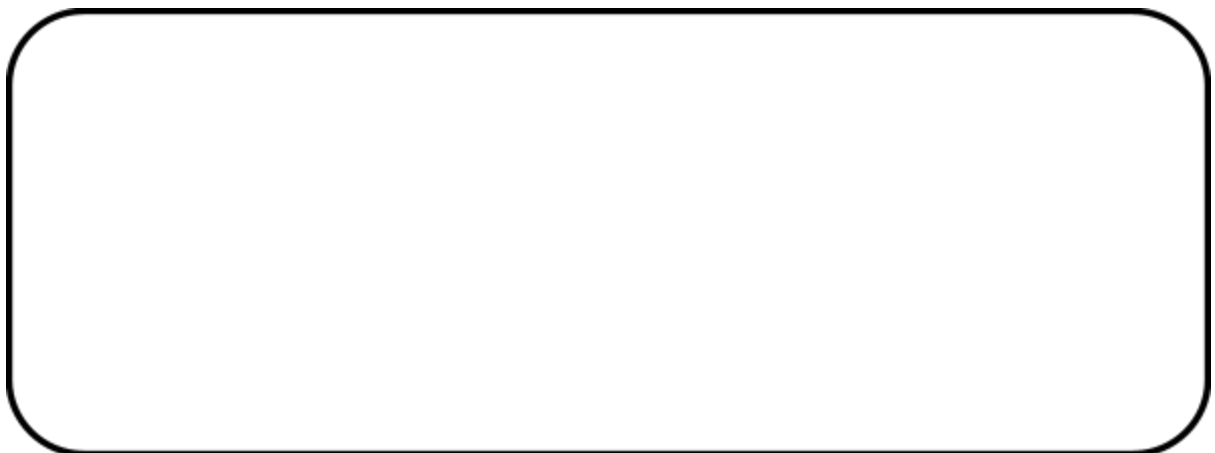
This method helps ensure that your goals are clear and well-defined so you know what exactly you want to do (specific), quantifiable to track progress (measurable), realistic and attainable based on your current resources, skills, and circumstances (achievable), aligned with your overall objectives and values (relevant), and have a specific timeframe or deadline for completion.

Here's an example of applying the SMART method to a goal:

Non-SMART Goal: "I want to say 'no' more often."

SMART Goal: "I will say 'no' whenever I want to without giving any explanation by following the steps described in Recipe #4 of The Anti Imposter Cookbook."

Importantly, when defining your goal, write it down instead of just thinking it in your head. According to Brian Tracy (author of Eat that frog!) doing so will increase your chances of achieving your goal by 5x to 10x. Hence, fill in the space below by copying down the SMART goal above or (even better) writing down your own variation of that goal:



Ingredients

for Recipe #4

Saying 'No' Blueprint

Extra 1: Stay on your side of the net.

Extra 2: Say 'no' early..

Layer 4: Say 'no' without saying no.

Layer 3: Express warmth and appreciation.

Layer 2: No apologies.

Base Layer: 'No' is a complete sentence.

Recipe #5:
Dismantling overthinking

As I explained in great length in my eBook *The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula*, one of the key lessons to learn on your journey to rediscovering your self-belief and feeling good enough is that discomfort is inevitable.

Choosing the path of embracing rejection and developing a healthy level of selfishness will inevitably lead you to moments of being flushed with all kinds of uncomfortable feelings, such as doubt, anxiety, guilt and most of all fear. Fear of what others might think, fear of losing a friendship or a lover, fear of embarrassing yourself, fear of others seeing that you are nervous, and so on. The list of fears your brain can come up with is virtually endless.

If you are a classic people-pleaser you will, for instance, get anxious just thinking about the idea of calling out your friend on something. Like the fact that they have started to always cancel on you at the last minute recently, making you feel second-choice and unimportant in your friendship.

(Who hasn't been there, right?)

And generally, having feelings of discomfort is completely normal. Because if you have always been a people-pleaser, demanding of yourself to call someone out on something for the first time is like asking a bodybuilder to do ski jumping. It's a completely different sport. And a scary one too. So of course you are going to be afraid.

However, we can't let that fear get in the way of taking action regardless and calling our friend out on their behaviour. If we want to break out of never feeling good enough and doubting ourselves, we need to act despite any fears. We need to practise rejection and be selfish despite the feelings of discomfort that our brain flushes our bodies with. Only then will we rack up the currencies of self-esteem and reap the long-term confidence boosts that come from that.

Otherwise, we'll drown ourselves in always feeling second-choice and stay unhappy.

Nonetheless, I am not ignorant and realise that sometimes you will inevitably end up in situations where fear takes over. Where your subconscious (emotional) side of the brain gains full control and draws up devilishly beautiful worst-case scenarios. Where you end up in this overthinking spiral that makes you freeze and prevents you from taking the action that will take you to a better place. Where your inner monologue looks something like this:

"What if they resent me for speaking up? And then what if we end up arguing because of that? Or what if I upset them? I'd feel so guilty. And what if I lose them as a friend as a result of that? Omg no, I really don't want that. Maybe, I should just keep quiet. Surely this is the last time they'll cancel on me and they'll have time again for me next time. What did I do wrong that they all of a sudden don't want to spend time with me anymore anyway? Pisses me off! Maybe I should have been more interested when they last spoke to me about their new job... I will remember that for next time. Damn, maybe this is just all my fault."

Sound familiar?

That's ok. That's normal. Breaking out of these thinking patterns takes time. Your mind is like a muscle that needs to be worked out repeatedly to build new neural-highways, which wire you to see things like calling someone out on their behaviour as an easy exercise. Just like you can't expect yourself to lift 100kg from the get go, you can't expect yourself to change your mindset at the snap of a finger.

However, what we can realise instantly is this: The narratives that we tell ourselves aren't always the reality.

Because while our subconscious mind is an absolute master at creating worst-case scenarios, there is one thing that it absolutely sucks at: Our subconscious mind can't actually differentiate between reality and fiction.

And that means, when our subconscious is drawing up these worst-case scenarios it is at the same time making you think that they are real, even though they aren't... they only feel real.

I love this one quote from Matthew McConaughey, which summarises this perfectly. He once said that one of the best pieces of advice he ever heard from his college roommate's grandpa was this:

"I have had many crises in my life. Most of them never happened."

In other words, the narratives that we tell ourselves when we are overthinking. All the worst case scenarios that we keep thinking over and over, that give us a tight feeling in our chest, that makes us feel like we can't move, that makes us feel like we are going through a real crisis. They are almost never reality and therefore never happen. They only ever exist in our heads.

And realising this gives us great power. Because realising this naturally raises one question: Why would we allow these fictional stories to control us and prevent us from marching on on our journey to rediscovering our self-esteem?

That's what this recipe is about.

The following exercise is intended to break you out of the freeze that overthinking puts you in. It is designed to disarm our subconscious mind when it draws up any worst case scenarios that we think through on repeat and to give you a set of steps that put you back into motion. So that you can keep taking

action despite your fears, keep practising rejection and being selfish to provoke the therewith connected lifelong confidence boosts.

Let's get cooking.

Method (à la Mark Manson)

At the core of this recipe for breaking out of any overthinking spiral stands a mantra that even the famous Roman Emperor Marcus Aurelius subscribed to almost 2000 years ago: You have to see things for what they are.

In other words, to deal with the emotional rollercoaster that overthinking puts us through, we need to apply logic, critical thinking, and questioning ourselves. Doing so will allow us to wash away the fictional paintings of our subconscious mind and redirect our focus to the facts, i.e., actual reality. Which we can then use to make a rational decision about what we should best be doing next. Because only when we have a clear fact-based picture of what the situation at hand really is, are we able to figure out what action in line with our values and wants is.

Is it really staying quiet, tolerating our friend cancelling on us at the last minute, and feeling unimportant as a result of that? Or is it standing up for ourselves, calling them out on their behaviour and thereby showing ourselves that we deserve to be treated with respect?

Here is what I want you to do:

1. Pattern interrupt

Before you do anything else, the first thing you should do when you are in an overthinking spiral is to physically interrupt your subconscious mind from thinking.

Personally, I like to consciously say “Stop!” out loud.

This sounds overly simplistic, but is incredibly effective. Because speaking in general is a conscious task - not subconscious. It is not something that happens automatically in your brain (unlike overthinking) but something that requires you to consciously think and focus. E.g. on what to say, what words to use, and how to express yourself to get your message across.

Hence, even by just speaking a single word, you pull yourself from your subconscious mind that is responsible for overthinking the emotional, fictional narrative in your head back into your conscious, rational mind. And by using a word like “Stop!” which has been drilled into us as a trigger to be alert since being a child, this effect is strongly enhanced.

(Alternatively, you could use something like Mel Robbins’ 5-second-rule, which simply involves counting down from 5 out loud with the same effect.)

2. What is my problem?

Once you have stepped off the emotional rollercoaster by mentally interrupting yourself, before we try to resolve the situation we should first properly dig into what the underlying problem is for your overthinking.

Because only when we have properly defined the problem are we able to find an effective solution for it.

For that purpose, I want you to not just take the obvious answer of “I am scared to call out my friend on his behaviour.” But rather, I want you to dig a few levels deeper than that by repeatedly asking yourself “why?”. Now this is where things get a bit tougher because as you do this I want you to be 100% honest with yourself. And that’s not always the most comfortable thing to do. Because as you question yourself you are likely to have to face your insecurities and admit to your fears. But you can’t let that get in the way of being honest with yourself. The truth is unfortunately uncomfortable sometimes. However, only when you are 100% honest with yourself are you able to see things for what they really are and make effective changes as a result of that.

This could look something like this:

Level 1: What is my Problem (on the surface)?

A: I am scared to call out my friend.

Level 2: Why am I scared to call them out?

A: Because I don’t want them to resent me for speaking up. Because I don’t want to cause any arguments.

Level 3: Why do I not want them to resent me for speaking up? Why do I not want to cause any arguments?

A: Because I am scared of rejection. Because I am scared of the uncertainty of whether our friendship would stand an argument. Because I don’t want to risk losing them as a friend.

Level 4: Why am I scared of rejection? Why do I not want to risk losing them as a friend?

A: Because I believe that being rejected and losing them as a friend means that I am a bad person.

Bingo...

Your problem is not that you are scared to call out your friend. Your real problem is that you have the unhelpful subconscious belief that rejection (both giving and receiving it) makes you a bad person. Your real problem is that you are too afraid that if you reject your friend's behaviour you get rejected by them in return. And that you believe that this is an inherently bad thing, but is it really?

3. What if I am wrong?

After we have identified what our real problems are, we can start applying some critical thinking by simply asking one question: What if I am wrong?

What if I am wrong about the fact that rejection is a bad thing? What if I am wrong about the fact that losing them as a friend means that I am a bad person?

Or even this...

What if I am wrong and they wouldn't actually resent me for speaking up? What if calling them out wouldn't actually cause an argument? What if I wouldn't actually lose them as a friend?

Do this for all the answers that you have given yourself in the previous step and watch how you start to drag yourself out of your worrying-cycle.

Most importantly, remember to be 100% honest with yourself. For any change to happen you must be wrong about something. And If you are unhappy because you feel second-choice and unimportant in your friendship, that is a strong

indicator that you are wrong about something. What if you are wrong about the fact that staying silent and avoiding the conflict is the better choice?

4. What would it mean if I was wrong?

Now that you have applied some critical thinking by questioning yourself, let's take it even deeper and ask yourself: What would it mean if I was wrong?

What would it mean if rejection wasn't a bad thing? If they didn't resent you for speaking up? If calling them out wouldn't end up in an argument? If you wouldn't actually lose them as a friend? Or if you do, if losing your friend wouldn't mean that you are a bad person?

The answer to all of these questions is always the same: It would mean that there is no reason not to do these things. It would mean that by speaking up, calling out your friend, and rejecting that kind of behaviour you wouldn't lose anything.

Quite the opposite is likely to be the case. If you are wrong, it would mean you are free to release all resentment that you have towards the other person. It would mean that you would satisfy your Id's need to be respected. It would mean that you would be free to show yourself that you value yourself and your time, and deem yourself important and worthy of being respected. Speaking up might even allow you to earn your friend's respect on a much deeper level as it shows that you are not afraid to show honesty even if it is uncomfortable.

5. Would being wrong create better or worse problems than my current problem?

In combination with gaining clarity over what it would mean if you were wrong, lastly also ask yourself whether being wrong would create better or worse problems than your current problem.

For that purpose, keep in line with the critical thinking that you are doing and look beneath the obvious answer.

Current problem:

“Staying silent has led me to feeling second-choice and unimportant. It also puts me in spirals of doubting myself and overthinking of what I might have done in the past that put me in this situation of being cancelled on all the time. It makes me overthink of what I could have done differently and what I should do differently next time. This is incredibly problematic because it is majorly distracting. It draws away my focus from things that might be more important. It prevents me from concentrating on and being present in the moment.

On a deeper level, avoiding rejection makes me feel like a coward. It also makes me feel a bit lost as I just always go with the flow. I always let myself be directed by others, their actions, their opinions, even in the smallest things, like deciding which takeaway to get. And that means I never really get what I actually want. I never really do what makes me actually happy.”

New Problem:

“Speaking up and calling them out on their behaviour would give me an intense but short moment of discomfort. I will feel so guilty for calling my friend out, I might feel really stressed and anxious if we end up in an argument and I might feel like a failure if I lose them as a friend.

On a deeper level, however, I know that I will be able to release all the resentment I have pent up inside of me towards them. I will be able to finally stop overthinking about all the things that could happen if I spoke up because I am actually doing it. I will be able to show myself that I value my time, that I think of myself as being worthy of being respected. I will be able to reinforce

what I know is important to me, e.g. being respectful of someone's time, which will reaffirm who I am as a person and thereby give me a feeling of confidence. And realistically, I just risk losing a person as a friend who doesn't respect your time and makes you feel second-choice. And if I don't give people the chance to reject me, I'll never know who my real friends are."

6. Making a decision

Once, you have dismantled your overthinking and have become clear on what your problem is, what it would mean if you are wrong about it and whether taking uncomfortable action would create better or worse problems, you will be in a position where you are able to make a really good decision on what the next best step is for you to take.

Goal Setting

Armed with these steps, I now want you to set yourself a process goal for how you are going to handle situations of drowning in an overthinking spiral that stalls you as you are about to take uncomfortable action like rejecting someone's behaviour, speaking up or putting yourself first.

For that purpose, I want you to follow the SMART method, which suggests that effective and achievable goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

This method helps ensure that your goals are clear and well-defined so you know what exactly you want to do (specific), quantifiable to track progress (measurable), realistic and attainable based on your current resources, skills, and circumstances (achievable), aligned with your overall objectives and values (relevant), and have a specific timeframe or deadline for completion.

Here's an example of applying the SMART method to a goal:

Non-SMART Goal: "I want to keep moving when overthinking sets in."

SMART Goal: "I will keep taking action despite any fears and overthinking by following the steps described in Recipe #1 of The Anti Imposter Cookbook every time I feel myself being stuck in an overthinking spiral."

Importantly, when defining your goal, write it down instead of just thinking it in your head. According to Brian Tracy (author of Eat that frog!) doing so will increase your chances of achieving your goal by 5x to 10x. Hence, fill in the space below by copying down the SMART goal above or (even better) writing down your own variation of that goal:

A large, empty rounded rectangular box with a black border, intended for the user to write their SMART goal.

Ingredients

for Recipe #5

Dismantling overthinking Journal Template

Step 1: My Pattern Interrupt:_____

Step 2: Figure out what your *real* problem is?

Level 1: What is my problem (on the surface)?

Level 2: Why_____?

Level 3: Why_____?

Level 4: Why_____?

Level 5: Why_____?

Step 3: What if I am wrong?

Step 4: What would it mean if I was wrong?

Step 5: Would being wrong create better or worse problems than my current problem?

Current Problem: _____

New Problem: _____

Decision:

Recipe #6:
Embracing Your Dark Side

What is something that makes you absolutely furious? That makes your blood boil and fills your head with imaginations of crimes you would love to commit, which you know full well are morally completely unacceptable?

Is it when you get cut off in traffic? Is it when your husband forgets to clean the dishwasher after you have asked him for the 3rd time? Or is it when your manager takes full credit for your work in a meeting even though they have contributed absolutely nothing to the outcome?

And much more interestingly... how do you respond to such moments?

Do you sit in your car screaming at the other person, shaking your head and giving not-so-nice hand gestures? Do you shout at your husband while aggressively unloading the dishwasher yourself? Or do you cause a scene during the meeting calling out your manager and setting yourself up for an extremely awkward situation?

Well, if you are a people-pleaser and approval-seeker, you are almost definitely going to do none of that.

You are most likely going to say nothing, just get on with unloading the dishwasher or your work without saying anything. You are going to contain your anger inside you, let the resentment build up and do nothing about it.

To give you a personal example, I used to get so annoyed with myself for spending a lot of time consuming stuff on social media that's completely useless. For hours I would scroll left, right and centre, almost automatically. And it didn't even make me feel good. The opposite was the case! With every minute that passed I got more annoyed with myself because I wanted to spend my time with something that was more meaningful to me. And yet I somehow couldn't stop. I built up more and more resentment towards myself.

And that is dangerous.

Because if you remember from *The ~~Never~~ Enough Formula*, the more you suppress something, the more it grows. And if you don't find a valve to release it, this pressure will start eating you up from the inside.

You set yourself up for feeling less alive and less engaged. You provoke cycles of negative thinking. And most importantly you partly starve yourself off your true self.

The last point comes back to the fact that our psyche is made up of three instances, the Ego, our mental judge, the Superego, our moral police that wants us to do everything that is good for 'the others', and the Id, our shadow that advocates us showing our truest inner desires, thoughts, and emotions, including anger and resentment.

Most people, unfortunately, suppress their Id in a quest to be a perfectly acceptable human being. They eat up their resentment. They distract themselves without consciously being aware of it, thereby only making it worse and sending themselves into downward spirals of negative thinking.

That's extremely unhealthy. Because really these emotions are a sign that we are not handling the situation right. That we are suppressing something. And that we should be figuring out what that is and then address it head on.

Hence, time to stop ignoring these signals and start listening to what your Id has to say.

This is what this recipe is about. In the following I want you to face, accept and own your shadow.

I want you to admit to yourself and others that you have certain qualities (because we all do) that are maybe not desirable in society but that are part of you and don't make you a bad person. And so we are allowed to let our Id vent sometimes, even when it has its moments of being unacceptable.

In other words, we need to exercise that dark side to us. Only then will it get weaker and in a way we can actually harness its power.

However, obviously you are not always going to have the most productive arguments with someone when you are releasing all your anger upon them.

Hence, in some situations it is worth finding a different way to release your anger and then start an argument with someone that is less emotionally-laden.

For that purpose. I want to give you a set of instructions for exercising your dark side in a controlled way. A way which still frees you from all the things that are pent up inside you, the resentment you have towards others, a situation, or even yourself. A way which allows your Id to vent and send yourself an incredibly strong signal that you and your views are important and that you believe in them and yourself so much in fact that you are willing to fight to defend them. But which also doesn't cause any harm to yourself or those around you.

So, ready to join the dark side?

Method (à la Dr. Aziz Gazipura and Dr. Steve Peters)

At the core of the following recipe stands doing the complete opposite of the above, i.e., the complete opposite of eating up your anger and resentment towards yourself and others.

For that purpose, we are going to use the power of reflection like we do in many others of these recipes. However, this time we are going to put a very different spin on it. Because this time, I am not going to give you a structured template to follow for your reflection, but rather this time I am going to give you a blank space.

A blank space which you can just fill with all your emotionally-laden thoughts and feelings just like they are in your head, completely unstructured. The idea behind this is that I don't want you to think too much. I just want you to vomit out all your thoughts, without holding back.

For that purpose, I suggest doing one of two options, whatever your prefer:

Go on a “rage walk”

Create a “Shadow journal” entry

For the former, I basically want you to go on a walk (could be in nature but even just doing circles around your kitchen table is enough) and I want you to release all your resentment by talking out loud to yourself.

The key hereby is that nobody can hear you. This is absolutely crucial. Wherever you go on your walk needs to be a safe environment where nobody can hear you.

Because just to reiterate the idea of embracing your dark side is that you don't hold back, even if it means ranting about another person in an intense way, calling them the worst names.

For the latter, I want you to use the blank journal entry template attached to this recipe or just grab a blank piece of paper and pen or just open a blank note on your preferred note-taking app and I want you to start writing down all your dark thoughts and feelings. The key hereby is once again that you vomit out your thoughts in a safe space, i.e., on a (virtual) piece of paper that nobody is going to read after you have drawn up the most brutal torturing agenda known to man on there.

The idea behind both exercises is in that context the same and two-fold.

On the one hand, talking out loud and writing your thoughts down forces you to put some structure to your thoughts. Because in order to formulate them you have to put them in structured sentences and paragraphs that make sense. And that leads to two things.

Firstly, by putting structure to your thoughts that race up and down in your brain you gain clarity. Clarity over what the true reason is that you are so annoyed or angry and therefore what your problem is that you need to address.

Secondly, your brain immediately comes up with ideas for how this problem could be addressed, giving you some ideas that you can take away to craft a potential solution.

But most importantly, when you go on a rage walk or create a journal entry in your shadow journal, you take your thoughts out of your brain and into the world or on paper. You release yourself off them and therefore prevent them from bothering you any more.

That's where the real power of this exercise lies. Vomiting out all our negative emotions gives your Id what it wants, it allows it to release all the pressure, resentment and rage that is pent up inside you and therefore resets you.

Here is an example from a personal reflection I did on the 29th May 2022 while I was completing some group work as part of my Master's degree (I anonymised names for obvious reasons):

"Alright, here come the highlights and lowlights. So firstly on Thursday I got so pissed off because we had this proposal to finish and XXX did basically nothing for it. And then the little research that they did is completely irrelevant! It's like they still don't really know what we're doing! I am the only one here coming up with all the ideas, writing it all up in good English, making sure it all looks good, is properly referenced, etc. they can't even do that properly! And then AFTER we submitted the proposal, i.e., after it was too late (!), then they start questioning what we're doing! It's like they are a constant hindrance, I am going a bit insane here. But clearly my leadership skills are terrible here as well, I don't know what to do! Maybe I need to allocate more tasks to them, ask for their opinion or something else, I am not sure, but I need to sit down actually to have a proper think about it."

Goal Setting

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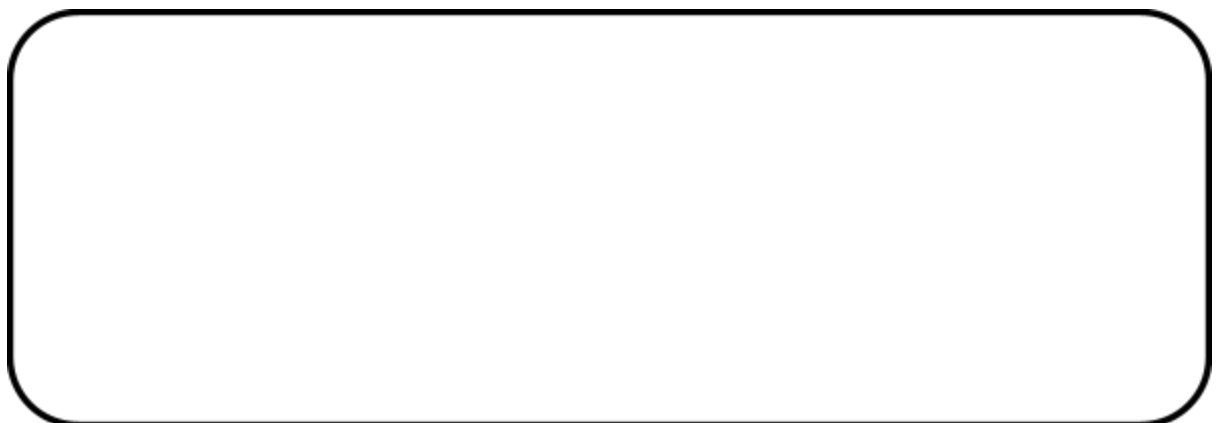
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Ingredients

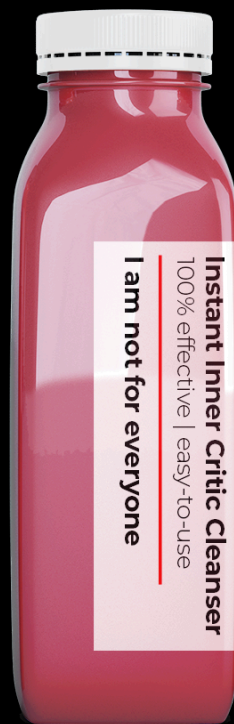
for Recipe #6

My Shadow Journal

Journal page with 20 horizontal dashed lines for writing.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dashed lines.

Instant **Inner Critic** Cleanser



**ANTI
IMPOSTER
CLUB**

I am not for everyone...

Dear Reader,

I want to give you arguably the simplest but maybe also the personally most often used little technique to help me deal with the Anti Imposter discomfort that comes from pushing myself to practise rejection, be selfish and thus continue to build my self-esteem.

It goes like this: Whenever you find yourself in a situation where you contemplate sharing your opinion, doing something courageous, or saying something controversial to the conversation at hand, and you can feel the fear/doubt/anxiety rising inside yourself of being looked at funny, of people disagreeing, or of being thought of as stupid, or of receiving any other sign of disapproval, simply tell yourself this:

"I am not for everyone."

This is so powerful. It literally disarms any worry that you might have about how others are going to react to what you have to say or feel like doing.

Consider these examples of what our overthinking spirals may contain and then watch how telling yourself "I am not for everyone" disarms every single one of them:

"They are all gonna talk behind my back about how I am so boring, when I say that I'd rather stay at home than come out drinking... actually who cares... I am not for everyone and who says that being fun means going out drinking every weekend?!"

"The plumber is going to be so annoyed when I tell him I am still not happy with how he has done our bathroom...Fine, maybe I am a perfectionist, but that's me, I am not for everyone."

"Maybe I should just stay quiet with my opinions this time, they always seem to cause tension in the group...actually no, I deserve to say what I think, and if people disagree then that's ok, I am not for everyone."

See how, this little sentence, disarms any sort of doubt, fear, or anxiety and validates your thoughts, words, and behaviours?

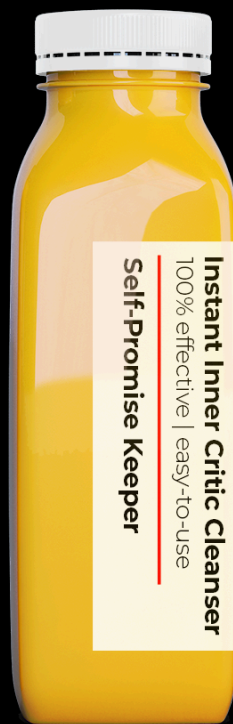
Here is a little challenge for you: Watch yourself today and whenever you find yourself in a situation, where you are hesitant to do something because you are afraid of what the others are going to think of you or say to you, tell yourself "I am not for everyone." Watch how it eradicates your doubt and then go ahead and do or say the thing you want to do/say.

Message me how it went! I'd love to know.

Kind regards,

Stefan

Instant **Inner Critic** Cleanser



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Self-Promise Keeper...

Dear Reader,

To round off this trio of instant inner critic cleansers, I want to give you another beautifully simple yet shockingly effective technique that gives you an instant confidence boost.

And that technique is to

"Make little promises to yourself and KEEP them."

Something beautiful happens when you keep the promises that you make for yourself. Whenever you do, you get a little rush, a feeling of success, as if someone put fuel to the fire inside you. It is so personal as well because when you keep a promise to yourself, only you know that you set it for yourself, you witnessed and experienced all the detail of the effort, time, and discomfort that went into keeping that promise, which makes the feeling of success all more personal.

And these promises could be anything. It could be that you tell yourself to make your bed every morning for a week straight. It could be that you promise yourself to go for at least a 30 minute walk every Saturday.

What happens when you keep these promises, is that you send yourself signals that your wishes and therefore your are important. It shows you that you are capable of doing what you set out to do, that you are capable of going after your own goals and that you are capable of rejecting what gets in the way of keeping that promise and enduring the discomfort that comes with that.

And that feels incredibly powerful.

Pro Tip: To make it more likely that you actually stick to these promises, make them really specific.

As an example, instead of setting yourself the goal of “go for a walk everyday”, make the promise to yourself to “go for a 30-minute walk in your local park right after you finish work on your work-from-home days”.

The specificity eliminates the overthinking that kicks in on the days when you can’t be bothered to stick to your promise where your brain is trying to find excuses by coming up with all sorts of questions like “where am I even going to go?”, “I have got so many other things to do, where am I even going to fit in that walk?”, and so on.

Hence, I dare you now.

Set yourself that smallest promise that you can think of and stick to it for 30 days.

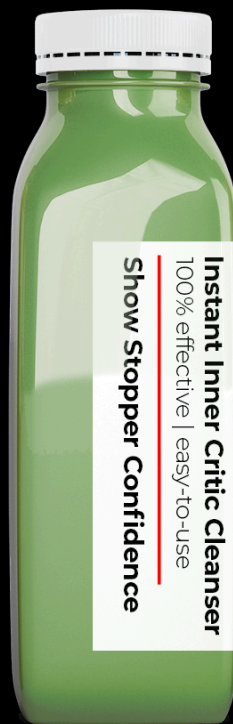
Here is a list of ideas for you to start with:

- Make your bed everyday straightaway after you brush your teeth
- Go for a 30-minute walk in your local park right after you finish work on your work-from-home days
- Do one lesson on Duolingo/Headway/any other learning platform before you go on social media in the evening
- Choose ONE compulsory goal from your To-Do Liste that you want to achieve and do so

Kind regards,

Stefan

Instant **Inner Critic** Cleanser



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Show Stopper Confidence...

Dear Reader,

As I was looking through my notes in my task of finding the key to building true self-esteem I stumbled across these 5 practical exercises on how to appear more confident and I immediately thought, I have to share this.

I love them not only, because these exercises are extremely specific and easy-to-understand but also because they are incredibly actionable. You can literally start using them right after you finish reading this.

They are basically based on one simple premise:

💡 **Confidence is a skill.**

Thus, confidence is something that **all of us** can have, that we can **learn**, and more importantly, that we can **practise** to become true masters at it.

However, unlike with some skills like coding, where we can just sit at home in front of our computer for hours on end and practice programming without anyone watching until we get good at it, to practise confidence we have to take a different approach.

Fake it till you make it

Have you ever given a presentation, sang a song in a karaoke bar, or taken part in any other social activity, in which you were the centre of attention and felt extremely uncomfortable and insecure about the things you were saying or doing, in which your knees were weak, your hands were shaking, and you could literally feel that drop of sweat running down your spine? However, for some reason, afterwards people came up to you and complimented you on your *solid*

performance, your composure, and the confidence you radiated, leaving you a bit baffled since you felt like you were "screaming inside" all the way through?

If you do, then you have experienced a highly interesting phenomenon:

💡 **We as the observer cannot differentiate between someone who is exhibiting real confidence and someone who is exhibiting *fake* confidence.**

Understanding this phenomenon is very helpful. Why?

Because it means that in order to practise confidence, we don't have to actually be confident, we just have to ***appear confident***. We can put ourselves in uncomfortable situations and actively practise appearing secure in ourselves and harness the therewith connected benefits such as appearing more credible, likeable, and trustworthy without the others around being able to notice that the confidence we radiate is fake and that we are actually feeling insecure.

Over time, however, this feeling of insecurity will fade away and you'll start to *become comfortable with being uncomfortable*. You are going to make more and more positive experiences, like being complimented on your solid performances in front of others, you'll get used to conducting yourself in situations that get your heart pumping a little faster so that eventually, the fake confidence you are practicing is going to translate into real confidence.

If you think about it, when you received that compliment after your presentation, which made it clear that you *appeared* confident, didn't that actually make you *feel* more confident about yourself?

Great! So let's get our confidence workout gear out and start practising ***appearing*** more confident.

Here are five exercises to get you started.

1. Hit the Pause Button

One of the most common things that happens when we are put in an uncomfortable situation in which we feel insecure is that we start getting nervous. Maybe we are being asked a question in a meeting that we don't know the answer to and all of a sudden our heart starts racing and we are hastily looking for something to say. We don't want to make it obvious that we don't know and the silence is killing us inside and so we start talking. FAST. We seem to become a race commentator or an Eminem double and aimlessly ramble on about whatever thoughts come into our head in the hope to somehow answer the question, however, knowing for well that whatever we say makes absolutely no sense and we are just doing it so we don't seem like we have got nothing to say.

However, if we do this, we have already lost. Those around us can immediately sense our insecurity and that that we don't know the answer to the question. They will see our attempt to cover up our lack of knowledge as a rather negative response, which diminishes their trust in our abilities and our image as a confident person.

Instead, we need to *hit the pause button*. To appear more confident you have to **consciously take pauses** when speaking. Rather than be afraid of the silence and fill it with aimless rambling, embrace it. Taking a pause gives you power. It allows you to radiate a calmness about yourself that suggests your confidence and conviction in the things you are saying. It heightens the tension in the room in your favour and gives whatever you are going to say next a lot more weight. It is also a good way of acknowledging a good question, which shows your appreciation and respect for the person who asked it.

But what if you really don't know the answer? How can you still appear confident?

2. Admit that you don't know

In situations where you don't know the answer to a question, don't be afraid to just say "*I don't know that.*". Being straight up and honest with others will be appreciated infinitely more than nervously rambling on about something, making it clear this way that you don't know. People appreciate people who speak the (sometimes unpleasant) truth and have respect for those who are willing to show vulnerability.

It makes you seem very trustworthy and confident as by willingly disclosing a vulnerability you are giving others a clear opportunity to attack you, but appear very secure in your abilities to handle any such attacks.

Further, explain that while you don't know the answer now, you will take steps x, y, and z to get the answer. This way you show your willingness to take responsibility, which is connected to the willingness to take a risk, and your belief in your ability to solve the problem at hand, which are signs of confidence.

3. Don't "just" do it

Next up, to raise your appearance as a confident person you have to start reducing your usage of the word "just" to avoid the belittling effect it has on what you are saying.

For instance, if you are giving a presentation at work to your management committee, which consists of people who are naturally busy, don't say "I *just* wanted to quickly show you these statistics here.". By using the word "just", you indicate that you are unsure about whether what you are about to say is actually really relevant or whether it is rather a waste of the other person's time, but since you are not sure you are going to talk about it anyway, *just* in case it is relevant.

That's not a very confident appearance. Instead, you could simply say "I would like to draw your attention to these statistics here.". This simple sentence without the usage of *just* highlights much more that you think that the information you are sharing is something your audience should care about, making you appear confident about your ideas.

4. Learn to control your voice

Everyone knows that one guy in the group, who naturally has got quite a loud voice, can simply talk over every background noise and doesn't seem to be afraid of others overhearing his conversations, making them appear quite confident.

Unfortunately, a fair few of us, myself included, don't have that "gift", and talk with a rather quiet voice, which makes us *appear* shy and afraid to speak out what's on our mind, rather than confident, even though we might not necessarily be afraid.

However, there is a simple trick to overcome this. We have to learn how to control our voice and **speak more clearly**. If you speak quietly but very clearly, people will still be able to perfectly hear what you are saying and you will seem just as fearless to share your thoughts and enter discussions as the guy with a naturally loud voice, which ultimately, makes you appear more confident.

The best way to speak more clearly is through practising speaking exercises, which could include tongue twisters like the ones listed [here](#).

5. Exercise your inner caveman

Overall, to appear more confident, we have to exhibit a degree of calmness that suggests that we are in control of the situation. Hence, why we should take pauses and not *just* say something to fill the silence or because we are unsure

whether it is relevant or not, and why we shouldn't rely on shouting to show that we are willing to put ourselves out there.

Unfortunately, this is sometimes hard to do, especially if we find ourselves in situations in which we feel so uncomfortable that our biological reflexes will get the better of us and trigger our fight-or-flight response, trying to prepare us for running away and escaping from the situation.

All of a sudden our heart rate starts beating faster, our breathing rate increases, our pupils dilate, adrenaline and cortisol rush through our body, and so on. The worst thing we can do in such moments is to try to suppress these responses, as they will just continue to build up within us. What we should do instead is exercise our inner caveman:

1. **Flex your bum and thighs.** As part of the fight-or-flight response, our body is increasing the blood flow in our legs and bum area with the intention to help us be able to run away faster and escape the situation we are in as quickly as possible. Hence, by flexing our bum and thighs, we trick our body into thinking we are running away, which will release the fight-or-flight response.
2. **Prayer position.** We could also take the prayer position or alternatively lift our arms, open up our chest and try to push up against a wall as hard as we can. Similarly to the above, by doing so we flex our muscles and thereby trick our body into thinking we are fighting, which will reduce our fight-or-flight response.
3. **4-7-8 breathing technique.** Lastly, to exercise our body's response of an increased breathing rate to supply our muscles with more oxygen, we can employ the 4-7-8 breathing technique. For that purpose, we will breathe in through our nose and mentally count till 4, then hold in the air for 7 seconds, and then breath out through our mouth for 8 seconds. After we repeat this cycle 3 more times.

Hope this is useful to you!

Stefan